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Emotional (Dis/Un)entanglement in Becoming an Academic in the Neoliberal Era: Dialogising Transnational Accounts of Being, Thinking and Feeling

Mahtab Janfada[1] | Angel M. Y. Lin[2] | Fei Victor Lim[3] | Jiajia Eve Liu[4]

[1]Faculty of Education, The University of Melbourne, Melbourne, Australia | [2]The Education University of Hong Kong, Hong Kong, China | [3]English Language and Literature, National Institute of Education, Nanyang Technological University, Singapore, Singapore | [4]Faculty of Humanities and Social Sciences, City University of Macau, Macau, China

Correspondence: Mahtab Janfada (Mahtab.janfada@unimelb.edu.au)

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ABSTRACT

This paper explores the complex emotions and affective challenges that academics might experience in their journey of becoming within neoliberal higher education contexts transnationally. These are examined in entanglement with intricate social, ideological, political and racial factors across different stages of academic careers. Informed by a theoretical and conceptual framework in relation to affect and agency in plurilingual contexts and through a dialogic methodology, diverse accounts of four transnational academics in language education are presented in a series of embodied or online, synchronous or asynchronous dialogic events to explore and embrace the complex and entangled emotions. Instead of offering an instrumental solution for these complex challenging feelings, the authors attempted to untangle these emotional events of being, thinking and feeling across diverse scenarios and put forth an affective and agentive approach for a richer and more sustainable process of becoming in the neoliberal era.

摘 要

本文探討在新自由主義高等教育背景下跨國學者們在成長過程中可能經歷的複雜情緒和情感挑戰。這些情感複雜性和挑戰將結合學者學術生涯不同階段錯綜複雜的社會、意識形態、政治和種族等因素得到檢視。基於多語背景下有關情感和能動性的理論和概念框架, 以對話式研究方法, 從不同角度記述了四位語言教育領域跨國學者所經歷的一系列親身或線上、同步或非同步的對話事件, 探索和接受其各種複雜交織的情緒。對於這些複雜且充滿挑戰的情感問題, 作者們並沒有提供工具性解決方案, 而是試圖理清這些跨越不同處境有關生存、思考和感受的情緒事件, 並為新自由主義時代探索更豐富可持續成長過程提出了一種有關情感和能動性的思路。

1 | Introduction: Untangling the Tight Knots

There has been much scholarly work in the past two decades delineating the ideological grounds of the incursion of neoliberalism in higher education (Giroux 2014; Olssen and Peters 2005; Shahjahan 2020; Sutton 2017). Santamaría (2020) argues that neoliberalism, as a capitalistic model, has led to the marketisation of universities, where they are transformed

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into businesses, and the commodification of education, where students are deemed as customers and academics are evaluated on performance-based metrics. Commodification of education, academic labour and the contested notion of 'impact' and quantification of outputs have now become normalised as part of the higher education system in the neoliberal era (Sutton 2017). Our paper aims at exploring and examining the complex emotions and affective challenges that academics may go through in the process of their ideological becoming under such a system.

While there are works which suggest ways to succeed or thrive in the system (Cannella and Koro-Ljungberg 2017; Maisura and Helmes 2019; Zembylas 2021), we argue that these suggestions might further reinforce or perpetuate the neoliberal ideologies by suggesting ways to increase citations or measurable outputs. Acknowledging the necessity of these endeavours to help academics survive in developing and shaping their career trajectory, authors of this paper are keen, through dialogising their lived experiences, to untangle the tight emotional knots and to explore the factors which might have contributed to these emotional entanglements. The aim is for us, through reflecting on our personal journeys, to collectively, re-conceptualise and re-weave the career carpet in a more meaningful, colourful and agentive way. Instead of seeking coping strategies for sustaining and succeeding in the system at the expense of ignoring our affective well-being, we seek to understand the source and nature of these emotions and how they are entangled with other factors in the process of becoming an academic in today's neoliberalised world and how we can navigate our emotions in a more meaningful way. Through offering our engagement with emotional (dis/un)entanglement, we challenge the discourse of higher education that promotes a monologic, linear view of language, self, and knowledge development. In this light, we seek to address and confront the impression of being 'emotional', 'uncertain', or 'vulnerable' often associated with early career scholars and to depict how these feelings are evolving all through the academic career and are entangled with other explicit and implicit factors.

The authors of this paper are academics in language education. We are inspired by critical theory in our teaching and researching in plurilingual and multicultural contexts of education. Importantly, we are at different stages of our academic career (Angel is at the professoriate level, Mahtab and Victor are at midcareer level and Jiajia is an early career academic) and we are located at different universities across Asia (Hong Kong, Macau, Singapore) and Australia (Melbourne). We acknowledge that neoliberalism in itself is not an agentive phenomenon, rather it is an ideological approach which has permeated higher education institutions in different ways and to different extents. For Mahtab, neoliberalism is evident in the commercialisation of education, mainly through attracting international students who strive hard to get admission at her university due to its 'capital' as a high-ranking research-driven university in the country with high research output. For TESOL students in particular, it is most appealing as they accrue symbolic capital in an English institution with the associated 'English native-speakerism' ideology. Interestingly, for other co-authors though in universities in non-Western countries they too experienced neoliberalism strongly.

For Angel, the universities in Hong Kong are evaluated chiefly on their research output and their international ranking, and thus, the pressure of 'publish or perish' is high. This is complicated by the requirement to publish in 'international' research journals, which actually means journals based in Western, English-speaking countries. This presents both a language issue and an epistemic and cultural issue. International theories usually refer to Western-derived theories, and international journals refer to English-language journals. This incursion of neoliberalist ranking culture based on research output metrics in Western-based English language journals was first problematised in Hong Kong by Lin in 2009.

The context is similar for Victor, who is at one of the globally top-ranking universities in Singapore, where the expectations from faculty members are high, especially when it comes to promotion and tenure applications. Faculty members are expected to excel in the aspects of research, teaching and service, with strong performances evident across various metrics valued by the university, such as research publication output and teaching feedback.

For Jiajia, it can be observed that universities' participation in global university ranking systems may boost their development by advancing their research agendas and enhancing international visibility, while it also heightens expectations for academic staff to publish in international journals and to quantify their research output and impact.

We share stories from emotional moments we experienced in our teaching, research and leadership/service where neoliberal ideologies potentially conflict with our ethics of being an affective and agentive educator and academic. Collectively, as a community, we explore how we can untangle those knots and reweave the vision for ourselves and hopefully for others.

In this paper, we relate our experiences to the understanding of emotion as an entangled phenomenon (Sah 2023b) manifested in diverse encounters, and employ the notion of 'entanglement' in our research constructs, including theoretical and conceptual framework (using the PAA Model and 4T Lenses, elaborated in following sections), methodological framework (dialogic methodology) as well as in the design of study (embodied/disembodied, a/synchronous dialogues transnationally). Our discussion and reflections, in turn, reveal and, in essence, dis/untangle the emotions emerging from researchers' utterances. We conclude by offering implications for the complexities and intertwined nature of affect in educational contexts across times and spaces.

2 | (Dis/Un)tangling the Scholarship: Contextualising Affect in Neoliberalised Higher Education

Neoliberal ideology, characterised by market-driven reforms and international competition, has profoundly permeated higher education institutions worldwide. The emphasis on competition, efficiency and quantification of outputs has led to the commodification of education, where institutions are viewed as businesses and students as customers (Olssen and Peters 2005). Redefined by neoliberal policies, universities are transforming into business entities which focus on market competitiveness, student-as-customer models, and performance-based metrics.

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This, in turn, marginalises non-economic values and potentially undermines academic freedom and critical inquiry, essential to a democratic society (Santamaria 2020). This shift has challenged traditional values of universities, such as intellectual curiosity, knowledge production, social responsibility, and community engagement, as well as having a significant impact on the affective experiences of educators and students (Giroux 2014; Sutton 2017). Research has reported that academics in tertiary institutions experienced significant emotional stress, such as feeling overwhelmed, undervalued, and disconnected from their work due to the increasing demands in performance metrics and accountability (Shahjahan 2020). Maisuria and Helmes (2019) describe the neoliberal university that, with its managerialism, has led to an emphasis on performance metrics, publication outputs, and student satisfaction scores, which often affect academics' job security and career progression. This has contributed to job precarity and mental health issues amongst academics in this high-pressure environment. Faculty members are also often compelled to navigate their own emotional experiences while attending to students' expectations and emotional needs, which adds to their emotional labour (Nixon and Scullion 2022).

In response to these challenges, there have been attempts for potential alternative affective practices. Zembylas (2021) addressed the affective dimension of resistance in critical pedagogy (e.g., critical engagement with ideas and experiences that create affective spaces for alternative counter-conduct practices) to offer insights and understandings of resisting neoliberal policies and practices. Cannella and Koro-Ljungberg (2017) called for collective effort and collaboration within and beyond academic communities to create and support diverse cultures of thinking and acting as a way to counter and eliminate forces of neoliberalism. In light of the increasing competition and mental health challenges amongst academics, Maisuria and Helmes (2019) advocated for understanding the demands of productivity while finding niches for personal research interests within institutional goals,

In the specific context of language education, scholars addressed the notion of affect and emotion profoundly. De Costa and Nazari (2024) conceptualised 'emotions as pedagogy' as they discussed the L2 educators' emotional labour and emotion labour. Similarly, research advocated for highlighting the important place of emotion in conducting professional development courses (Nazari and Karimi 2024), in collaborative teaching and research spaces (Cinaglia et al. 2024; Song and Valentine 2024) and having an open dialogue about those emotional challenges (Hopkyns and Dovchin). Sah (2023b) elaborated on emotion and imagination in the EMI context and recent scholarship exploring the place of AI in the emotional experiences of researchers (Farangi et al. 2024). Sarah Benesch (2017, 2023) was a pioneer in attending to emotions in academic English and critical literacy pedagogies and exploring how emotions are (de)constructing an individual's identity, especially in transnational, multilingual contexts of neoliberal and neo-colonial higher education. Her work discussed how emotions such as hope, disappointment, and compassion influence classroom dynamics, shaping both students' and instructors' experiences in an educational system which increasingly focused on individual productivity and competition. As such, addressing the complexities of managing emotions in neoliberalised educational contexts and the importance of emotional awareness is a crucial, though often neglected, area to address.

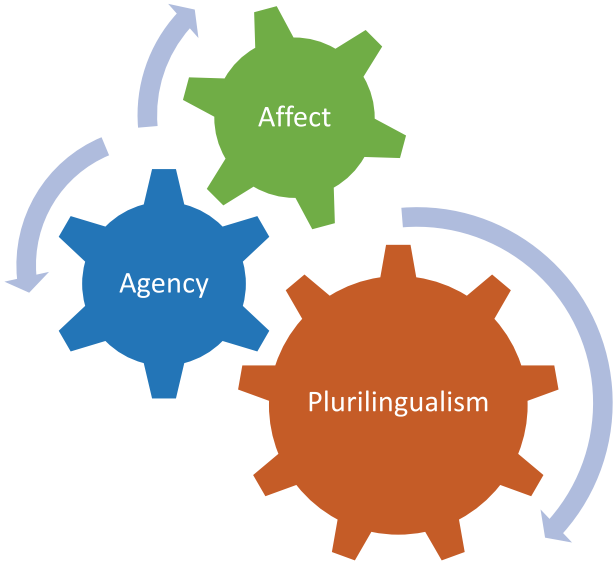

FIGURE 1 | The PAA model (Adapted from Lin 2024). [Color figure can be viewed at wileyonlinelibrary.com]

3 | Entangled Theoretical and Conceptual Framework: The PAA Model and 4T Lenses

Lin and Chen (Forthcoming) proposed the PAA (plurilingualism, affect, agency) model to transform English medium education in an ethical and responsible manner (Figure 1). And we will draw on this model as our theoretical conceptual lens for this paper model. This model is accompanied by the 4T lenses as a heuristic that encapsulates translanguaging, trans-semiotising, trans-knowledging, and trans-culturing. The PAA model and 4T lenses are elaborated in different contexts with different dynamics. For instance, in relation to recent Gen AI, Lin and Chen (Forthcoming) used the PAA model and 4T lenses to guide teachers and students' critical engagement with Gen AI.

With the PAA model, they advocate for the recognition and appreciation of diverse linguistic, epistemic and cultural resources, challenging the dominance of monolingual, monoglossic biases and fostering a more transculturally inclusive perspective.

As highlighted by Lin and Chen (Forthcoming) in their exploration of affective decolonisation and drawing on the insights of Sara Ahmed and Michalinos Zembylas, the PAA model advocates for the recognition of emotions as socially embedded practices, deeply intertwined with power relations (Ahmed 2013). Affective decolonisation involves acknowledging and challenging the often unconscious or subconscious emotional residues of colonialism embedded in both mainstream media texts, educational systems and technological systems. The PAA model emphasises the emotional and identity impact of language choices, recognising that positive experiences, such as pride and confidence, arise when learners are encouraged to use their full linguistic repertoires. By fostering a linguistically inclusive and emotionally aware

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educational space, the PAA model aligns with a transformative vision for education.

In this paper, we engaged critically with the PAA model and 4T lenses to analyse and elaborate on the entangled emotions and complex feelings that emerged in a dialogue amongst four academics transnationally. We are using this as our lenses to make sense of our dialogues and to discover the hidden or less explicit layers of emotion which were engaged with concepts such as race, gender and socio-cultural biases. Applying the PAA model, we reflect on how people react, resist, reject or appropriate some feelings or complex emotions.

The PAA model acknowledges affect in motion with contextual and social constructs and appreciation of individual and collective agency in plurilingual contexts of education. The model acts as a catalyst for our dialogic analysis of entangled emotions as we engage with it. In our discussion, we highlight how the PAA model and the 4T Lenses offer new ways of thinking about being, feeling and thinking in academia.

4 | Entangled Frameworks for Methodology, Method and Analysis: Dialogic Methodology

Aligned with the conceptual framework and the core query of this paper, a dialogic methodology will afford unpacking and uncovering of layers of complexity as it brings to the fore through dialogues. Drawing on the work of Bakhtin (1981, 1986), the Russian philosopher, language is in essence dialogic and encapsulates cultural, ideological and socio-political grounds. Bakhtin introduces the notion of heteroglossic voices to discover diverse ways of being, thinking and feeling where there is an ongoing tension between internally persuasive discourse and authoritative discourse. In the case of this paper, our collective voices can be construed as agentive, affective discourse in response to the dominantly monologic discourse of the neoliberal system.

Dialogic methodology is described by Bakhtin (1986, 135, 159) as a 'special science (scientific discipline)' that has its own governing principles which set it apart from others. It views 'interpretation as the discovery of a path to seeing (contemplating) and supplementing through creative thinking.' It can, therefore, be understood as a highly creative process in thought and practice. It leads you to the stance you will ultimately take—orienting the questions you ask, the way you approach the field, the methods you use, and how you interpret your discoveries and share them with others. It is one of a multitude of methodologies at our disposal—whatever position we choose to take (White and Janfada 2025). It embraces the evolving and entangled process of rationalising the significance of research, generating curious questions and insights and using 'dialogue' itself as a method for interpreting meaning.

This methodology suits our paper particularly well because it does not begin with any set, pre-defined, default disposition, direction or even a research question, explicitly articulated. Rather, it is all evolved through and from authentic exchanges and genuine dialogues in an organic time and space, with provocation from earlier dialogic interactions. We were engaged in multiple dialogic circles, both synchronous and asynchronous, embodied and disembodied. We let the process of research guide us, confuse us, trigger us and define our directions as the space of query. Not knowing about the topic beforehand or focus, we all wove the strings together. We are using 'entanglement' not only to show the complexity of emotions but also in how this paper came together, entangling multiple stories from different times and spaces both geographically and career-wise. We also used 'dialogue' as an entangled literacy practice, which is not about the content, explicitly articulated or uttered, but what and how it provokes. We let those interwoven layers come to the surface without interruption or trying to fix it or streamline it. As we will elaborate in detail in the next section, our data was a series of dialogic events, both in person and online, synchronous and asynchronous. We captured these dialogic narratives and then reflected together and individually to unpack and reshape the narratives. In this process, it became obvious to us that every time we revisited the dialogic moment, a new affective aspect came to the fore. We then had a thematic categorisation of our dialogues for the purpose of clarity to the reader, which involved the dialogic data entangled with its analysis. The next section will unpack these entangled data and analysis.

4.1 | Transnational Dialogues as Entangled Data

4.1.1 | In Person Dialogues

The first dialogic moment for the authors of this paper was through spontaneous conversations amidst conference sessions in a 2024 conference on language education where they met and attended multiple sessions across different topics related to sociolinguistics and critical scholarship in language education, among many other topics. In one of the post-conference events, authors discussed this special issue theme, as a general conversation, with no pre-determined agenda or argument. Reflecting on their potential emotional entanglement in their academic experiences, Mahtab was the first one who immediately recalled and shared some of the experiences and exposure in which she felt some complicated emotions were evoked, often associated with her racial and cultural identity. The first and boldest moment she shared was related to how her name, as the most powerful and affective identity matter to her, was pronounced and perceived by people in English context, and to the extent that one colleague suggested to her that she may change her name to 'Margaret' to be clear for others in terms of gender and also easier to pronounce and she can feel 'elegant' with Margaret. For BA, this was an emotional shock as she stated:

> Mahtab: I felt so empty with this comment; in my culture, names have a significant meaning, mostly with poetic association, so is my name with reference to moonlight. I do not like to substitute it with Margaret, I do not feel elegant in that. They may think I am too emotional, but I disagreed with the suggestion.

Jiajia was touched by Mahtab comment and wondered if this comment from a male colleague has any gender-bias or possibly racial bias and added:

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> I wonder how you managed your feelings then as it was your early days; in reflection, I think I am now less emotional or show less emotion compared to my earlier days in the academic context.

Jiajia's comments made us all reflect on whether the neoliberal system has incrementally and unconsciously made us a bit more numbed with our feelings or have we gotten used to hiding or suppressing emotions with no chance to disentangle it for ourselves so as to explore and understand the feelings more fully. This is, of course, different from the sense of professionalism that we must all adhere to in the academic context.

This brief initial dialogue made all of us more deeply contemplate on the moments of emotional entanglement in our journey to becoming an academic. For some of us, these emotional moments were recalled so immediately, and for others, such as Victor, it was surfaced with some time interval. This in itself shows the complex untangling process of our emotions linked to our being, thinking and occasionally surviving.

Victor shared his powerful and thought-provoking questions a few weeks after in our subsequent disembodied, asynchronous dialogue via emails, which led to our synchronous online meeting on Zoom to dialogise the matters more in depth and understand those moments and find our affect and agency amidst all these entangled knots.

4.1.2 | Asynchronous and Synchronous Dialogues

As mentioned above, our email exchanges continued after the conference, and we shared some thoughts regarding our entangled emotions and areas within which we felt these emotions more boldly. Provoked by Victor's ideas in our Zoom meetings, we decided to elaborate on these feelings under the main categories of teaching, research and leadership and service in academic contexts. We asked each other in particular to examine the following: When did we feel tension/unease emotionally or affectively? Why? How was it experienced? And where is our agency in all of these complex moments?

As this was a long dialogue, for the purpose of clarity and coherence, Mahtab analysed the interaction and presented it under themes which emerged from our dialogue and also visualises them in Figure 2. As stated earlier, we seek to present data and its analysis, persevering the sense of entanglement that has arisen from our recount and reflections of our individual experiences collectively.

4.1.3 | Workload, Voluntary Service, Free Labour and Emotional Labour

Jiajia began the dialogue by expressing her mixed (or entangled) feelings about the review process of research papers as part of contribution and service to the academic community and scholarship

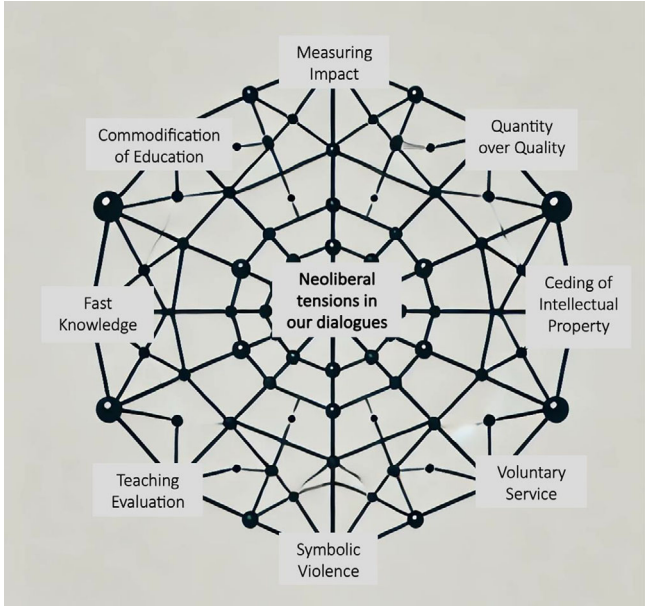

FIGURE 2 | Entangled neoliberal tensions in our dialogue. [Color figure can be viewed at wileyonlinelibrary.com]

> As an early-career academic, I was once quite excited to be invited to review papers for academic journals; I felt it showed the recognition of my research expertise. Gradually, it became quite time-demanding, and I had to spend long evenings on that. I am not sure if and how I should say no to those invitations. I have complicated feelings about this. Part of me feels it is my professional community service and I learn from the process, but on the other hand, it is quite demanding and adds to the labour.

Victor responded to Jiajia, acknowledging that even as a more experienced academic and editor of a few journals, he felt emotional about such academic labour:

> Yes, this feels like academic labour. I have this feeling when I approach peer reviewers to review papers or when I am asked to review papers for other journals. Also, the consignment of our intellectual rights to the publisher when we have to publish a paper in their journals and the free labour involving both time and effort which peer reviewers have to offer for journals owned by wealthy businesses is concerning

As one of the most senior academic and leading researcher in the field, Angel shared the same affective pressure:

> It is painful because the publishing industry is taking advantage of us, the voluntary labour; all the content, creation, reviewing, editing are all voluntary work, but then they are charging a lot. Somehow, we feel our good intentions, our citizenship is being exploited by the neoliberal system.

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Mahtab echoed these tensions in her recent experience with publishing an open access paper:

> I got an acceptance of a paper today and as we asked for open access option, they informed me about charging us for $3000; first I thought 'Wow, we are expensive!' But my co-author corrected me that we are not expensive, but publisher is.

Victor added his recent experience, which almost led to a satirical scenario when he had to pay the royalty to the publisher for reproducing a figure from his book in another publisher's book. He was bewildered by the situation but understood later that he has, technically, consigned the copyright to the figure he created when he included it in the book he had published earlier.

We all shared the feeling that the publishing industry, powered through the neoliberal system, makes our valuable work seem valueless, but as publishers package it, and commodify it, they profit and benefit financially from the academics' labour. Yet, ironically, academics are obliged to feel proud and 'grateful' for having published a paper in these journals. The journals, especially the top-tier ones, are highly valued by the institutions that have the power to withhold and confer rewards, such as promotion and tenure to its faculty members, thus making the choice not to publish in commercial journals non-viable.

We were all aware that this is how the high ranked publishing industry works and there is not much space for the individual academic's exercise of agency as such, and regardless of career stage, people might think they are reinforcing the capitalist chain of the academic industry. Such practices impact an individual's sense of self-worth, their unique voice and contribution to the realm of knowledge and the integrity of their academic work.

4.1.4 | Impact, Quantification and De-Valuing Authenticity

This initial talk led to a more emotionally triggering concept of 'impact' as the core of the neoliberal system, defined narrowly through numbers and the quantification of academic deeds. We all echoed that in most meetings, related to teaching, research and leadership, high impact activities or so-called 'good news' are associated with high teaching evaluation rankings, number of publications, amount of grant/funding, neglecting all other diverse ways each academic can embrace passion and transformation in academia and beyond. This can potentially lead to a strong sense of devaluing a person and of the system/workplace. Despite being recognised and having been conferred several awards from his university for his teaching excellence, Victor opined that the teaching evaluation from students can potentially be detrimental to someone's career, when the feedback is not considered in a meaningful context and reported to the management through a list of digits and percentages. When the statistics are viewed devoid of the context, it may lead to an unhelpful focus on numerical scores where quantity is privileged over quality.

> Barthes (1972, 268) famously observes, "by reducing any quality to quantity…we [understand] reality more cheaply". But I guess, in a neoliberal context, when universities become corporations, this is how its staff performance in terms of teaching impact can be easily evaluated. In the past, teachers would do what they believe was pedagogically and ethically right for students, even though it may be challenging and unpopular, as they were not worried about students' evaluation. But now in neoliberal system we need to focus on the students as customer, and this sometimes may compromise high standards. Pitching the lesson appropriately to challenge, but not overwhelm, the students, is a form of emotional labour, as I do wonder if I am doing them an ultimate disservice if I do not push them harder and further.

This fear or uneasiness with reductive evaluation of teaching was highlighted by Angel, even as a senior academic:

> Even for me as a tenured and senior academic, this brings emotional pressure; sometimes we need to sugar-coat our comments to students, as they always need to stay 'satisfied'; even I struggled with the choice of readings or number of readings, as I am worried they may find it too challenging. I can imagine how much more pressure an early career academic might be under to ensure satisfaction of customer.

Mahtab shared her recent frustration in one of the advanced subjects in the language program where she gave students full agency and freedom to bring their own voice and signature in final essay, but only two percent of the whole class even embraced it.

> I wondered what is wrong that even when we give them full freedom, they do not take it up. It makes me and my teaching team deflated after putting so much passion and energy to uplift the course and let them exercise their agency, without the constraint of template.

Angel made an astute observation regarding students' agency in the neoliberal era:

> Most of the time it is not their own choice to come to university; they are also very, very much stressed. They don't want to study this, but then they have to come in because of school principals asking them or their parents want their kids to graduate with a certain institute. So it is all branding, job market and commodification of education, which put both students and teachers in a difficult affective position.

All of us, however, agreed that at the end of the day, all academic evaluations and promotions are done by and through a narrow mechanism, where good teaching is assessed reductively and merely quantitatively. We also acknowledged that this quantification sometimes permeates to the leadership agendum of universities such as internationalisation or diversity

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and inclusion, and occasionally, diversity is defined by the demography, graphs and percentage, instead of true diverse, authentic ways of being, feeling, thinking and valuing.

4.1.5 | Fast Knowledge, Losing Signature and Playing Safe

As the issue of 'impact' showed itself most severely in the research and publication domain, Jiajia expanded this notion of reductive impact in research and how she reflected on quantity and quality as she tried to establish her research profile:

> There may be trade-off between the quantity and quality of research… In the past, a scholar devoted several years into a research project and came up with a book that may have a good or significant theoretical breakthrough. It was valued as great achievement. But in the current time, I wonder how academics can survive the job demands with such projects or devotion. It has to be fast and too many.

Angel responded to this fair concern, adding that:

> We need to acknowledge that the whole knowledge production and circulation ecology has changed; so much information now floating around, with internet, globalisation, AI, social media, etc, so we need to strike a balance between fast food publishing and slow ones.

Mahtab linked this fast knowledge to the lack of agency as she raised another side effect of all fast outputs in academia, which led to homogenisation of knowledge and encouraged safe path of research:

> I felt in the past conferences, almost all talks were about the same matter. It is hard to see people's signature or unique passion or agentive voice. So I felt like we are all in echo chamber. Some concepts are on trend, or receive more capitals, which encourage especially early careers to follow that route, or the route of their supervisors to be on safe side and guarantee publications.

Angel confirmed this issue as she added:

> Yes, not a healthy sign, consuming the same little repertoire of theories, not advancing the field, and playing safe. In this neoliberalist era and with the precarity of jobs, less people are willing to play agentive.

We discussed that being conservative might be perceived, especially by early careers, as a more strategic approach for career development and promotions as it may lead to higher citation and more pragmatic achievements, and this is a strong attraction for many scholars. This is exactly what neoliberal system promotes; whereas for those who strive to create their own path and look at things more critically and agentively, they may need to pay a higher price in terms of citation figures, appreciation of the work and acceptance for journals and so forth. This leaves them with another affective and internal dilemma on which path to choose.

4.1.6 | English Hegemony, Neoliberal Success and Symbolic Violence

The climax of our dialogue was when all these neoliberal tensions, and the place of affect and agency, reached the discussion of presenting and selling all this knowledge in and through English power and hegemony. This is where neoliberal system becomes more powerful through the political capital of English, as the language of power in global neoliberal universities.

For all of us as language educators, lecturing and researching on plurilingual, multimodal, multiliteracies pedagogies, it is another affective tension to conform to English-only norms and academic genres in order to publish.

Mahtab raised her constant tension in fitting her holistic, metaphorical way of building arguments and writing with conventional academic English, sometimes in the exaggerated form that dominant discourse urges individuals to be 'bold', 'assertive' and to think in a linear way:

> I tell a story differently, it is not always beginning with an introduction in a certain way, nor do I think atomically, for me all is entangled and evolves and usually through metaphors. I like to argue humbly yet rigorously. When it is too assertive, I feel I am lost, or my soul is not there.

> Angel highlighted this point: You touched upon a very important and less discussed point. Our academic conventions for publication are still very much imposed by Western ways of expressing and presenting yourselves. And, if you don't present yourself or your ideas in their ways, your academic intellectual scholarship won't win and thus you are under-valued.

Angel elevated this to signify this as symbolic violence:

> This is a kind of cultural and epistemic and rhetorical colonialism, I still feel very uncomfortable to be very assertive, and then, almost like I need to change my personality in order to fit into academia. It is more than an emotional labour, I am losing myself; it is a kind of violence.

We all echoed that this process and explicit and implicit demand permeate all through career stages and in all promotion applications as well; it takes huge affective pressure and impacts one's agency to write about him/herself in an imposed way, as BA described.

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4.1.7 | Our Agentive and Affective Response to Neoliberal Tensions

As we engaged in the above conversations regarding tensions and dilemmas in neoliberal higher education, we tried to find an agentive response to those tensions and challenges. Without being prescriptive, or seeking monologic solutions, we attempted to expand our perspectives and invite new ways of exercising agency, despite challenges, which underscores the affective aspect of academic career—beyond a job, but an identity construction process and ideological becoming.

Angel provoked this question to all of us in the dialogue:

> We know that neoliberal issues are like clichés now; it feels like we are all tied up into this mechanism but where is agency and change that we'd like to show?

As we tried to disentangle it and re-weave it more agentively, Jiajia referred back to the idea of reductive teaching evaluation and offered a brave positionality as she said:

> I actually try not to worry too much about those evaluation scores; I know in my heart I am doing my best capacity; I understand students might come from different backgrounds, and I try to create a constructive dialogue and relationship with them and enjoy the learning process together.

Victor similarly referred back to his idea of free labour and explained that he reconciled with his peer review services by seeing it as a form of philanthropy which draws on his expertise for the academic community.

> When I think about the peer reviews I perform on a weekly basis as volunteer work or charitable services, drawing on my expertise, for my academic society community, I feel less exploited and, so I try to promote this vibe among my circle as a way of caring for myself and others.

Angel refers to the main theoretical framework we introduced in the paper, the PAA model and 4T Lenses, suggesting them as a possible agentive and affective way to act with more compassion in the neoliberal context.

> We can apply translanguaging, trans-semiotising, trans-knowledging and trans-culturing in our students' assignments, in writing journals, as we do it now, and even in the tenure and promotion applications, doing journal reviews or books to give everyone a sense of being, valuing and recognition.

Mahtab shared examples of embracing these in her design of the courses she teaches and how students responded positively, though at first, they might have felt unsure about it.

The final comment from Jiajia tied up our entangled dialogue nicely:

> Such dialogues are healing itself. When I listen to experiences of other academics in different stages of career and the same nature of emotional burden, it makes me realise I am not alone and there are richer ways to become an academic in the neoliberal world. This dialogue for me is an entanglement of being seen, heard, valued, and this experience is also entangled into my becoming an academic.

5 | Discussions and Open Closure: Weaving Entangled Vision

Across the entangled data presentation and analysis in the form of collective dialogue, in the light of the PAA model, which has a particular focus on agency and affect in a plurilingual world, some meta-level themes emerged and are worth contemplating:

Ethical dilemmas: What was evident throughout the dialogue was a strong sense of dilemma raised by all four academics, as we were reflecting on moments in our journeys of academic becoming in diverse areas of teaching, research and leadership. As shown, there were moments when we found ourselves in uneasy positions, exposed to some kind of ontological, epistemological and methodological tensions. Relating to agency, torn between being an agent of change or a mere service provider to fee-paying students (Olssen and Peters 2005); acting as intellectual property and a writer/researcher or as free labour exploited by the publishing industry; a person believing in and embedding diversity and inclusion or acting as conformist to the university agendas, arguably reinforcing the capitalist space of internationalising (which is a code word for Anglicising) and commodification of education (Santamaria 2020). This is the time, we argue, as Bakhtin (1981) profoundly states, when authoritative discourse clashes with internally persuasive discourse. What Bakhtin suggests in this dilemma is moral addressivity: which is, to whom we are morally answerable and addressing our deeds? In essence, if we do all this academic work, potentially seen as highly emotional and labourious, for the higher good, for what fundamentally and at deepest level of existence, we feel morally and ethically right, then we do not find ourselves to be slaves of the neoliberal system, rather the opposite, we are using that as a strategic platform for bringing more awareness, autonomy, agency and affect to the fore, to live meaningfully, rigorously and freely in the plurilingual era.

A tangible, actionable example of this can be in academic meetings or supervision meetings where all staff are asked to articulate and identity their vision/mission and it surely needs to be aligned with university strategies. If in doing this task, we encourage each individual to relate this outer vision to their moral ethical vision, this may alleviate the pressure and make the mission holistic and meaningful. Relating specific aspects of the corporate vision to personal values empowers the individual to centre their labour and activities on what is personally meaningful for themselves.

This is how 'impact' can be reconceptualised as well, far beyond numbers, citations and funds; rather, each individual is impactful

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and valuable if they are answerable morally to what they do. Paradoxically, we argue that if this moral answerability becomes the main goal and vision of the academic journey, then all those neoliberal goals might, in one way or another, be ticked off too.

From the perspective of the PAA model, while the four of us are dedicated to pluralising our educational practices, our agency is constrained by neoliberal institutional policies and structures that incur emotional labour and significantly impact our affective well-being. Nevertheless, within this dialogic and supportive space, we find the strength to rebound, maintaining our commitments to our goals. Using the PAA model and 4T Lenses to recognise and raise awareness of the tensions we experience as academics in a neoliberal environment is a step forward in reconciling and mitigating the tensions. This also helped us to use this model as an evolving, organic framework which lends different insights in different contexts. For instance, can we carve out some space to do translanguaging in our publications? Can we draw on local ways of knowing in analysing research data? Can we mobilise local epistemologies and knowledge systems to contribute to our knowledge production?

Healing dialogue and well-being literacy: Neoliberal system incrementally shapes our process of becoming, in which we learn intentionally or unintentionally to hide feelings (Maisuria and Helmes 2019), as the system treats it as 'less valuable' and a sign of immaturity, naivety, vulnerability and insecurity. Occasionally these feelings are considered as disentangled, or atomistic, yet these feelings should be conceptualised beyond a linear or isolated feeling, such as being exhausted, or burnout or overwhelmed or even uncertain; rather acknowledging that all these emotions, affect and academic experiences are highly entangled and cannot be treated on its own and sperate from the context.

Relating to affect, it is only through dialogue and the contextual discourse of co-being, as well-stated by Jiajia, that these weak feelings fade away and are substituted by the sense of belonging, empathy, compassion and affective acknowledgements. Dialogue can let these frustrating feelings come to the fore and as we untangle them and receive the acknowledgement and recognition, we are able to see it from a different lens; in other words, when people are effectively recognised, their agency can be well exercised. Writing this paper together was an explicit example of valuing, respecting and giving prominence to such tensions and feelings. In our writing process and through our interactions and exchanges, we realised that entangled feelings are not explicitly evident, and only through discourses we could bring them to our own consciousness. Those dialogues were in themselves an awareness raising of feelings (suppressed or ignored, unacknowledged or unrecognised). Through dialogue and listening deeply to each other, we come to the awareness that at some stage we have been hurt, revealing the entangled nature of feelings. This has implications for academics, to create time and space for community-building, regardless of our respective career stage, to engage in dialogue about challenges and ways of engagement with these challenges, turning pain and pressure to possibilities so as to build our own narratives. Being an academic should not be a solitary and lonely journey, as the communal connections can offer invaluable support through sharing resources, experiences and guidance, which address the affect and agency dimensions in the PAA model.

This in turn has strong implications for what we argue as well-being literacy, which is beyond a clinical treatment of an emotion as a deficit or a problem, but rather to make every individual accountable for how we talk, listen, and express affect and compassion. This encapsulates empathy as a departure point but leads to compassion as an agentive status in which we give community a sense of worth as a valuable being. This also has implications for workplace discourse, including academic meetings and supervision or mentoring. Here, 'good news' should not be viewed solely through reductive 'impact' measures. Instead, it can be found in the deep and rich insights people share, an important teaching scenario, meaningful feedback from students, or even the honest acknowledgment of feeling puzzled about a grant or promotion application. It helps people's true selves, and their true capacities and true stories breathe behind the fake mask of 'strength,' which is more problematically interpreted as 'resilience.'

5.1 | Translanguaging, Trans-Semiotising, Transknowledging and Transculturing

As Angel theorised, and as we exemplified in our dialogic events, one way to foster a more agentive and affective process of becoming within neoliberal and neocolonial systems—particularly in English universities—is to integrate the perspectives of the 4T Lenses into our teaching, research, and leadership (Lin and Chen Forthcoming). As Mahtab expressed her emotional emptiness caused by how her name was treated, as well as her discomfort with writing her thesis or promotion application in a linear, assertive, and bold manner within a prescribed genre, it becomes clear that we need richer ways to value diverse ways of thinking, knowing, creating knowledge, articulating arguments and embracing the diverse linguistic and semiotic repertoires of individuals in plurilingual contexts of education. In this connection, we can consider how the 4T Lenses may help us in not trying to ignore or downplay our emotions, but rather to face the emotions and feelings with self-understanding and self-caring, and to genuinely share our experience and emotions with colleagues and academics in similar and different contexts, disciplines, and career stages. Through engaging in the processes of translanguaging, trans-semiotising, transculturing and transknowledging, we recognise and engage with our emotions and see them as possible ways to help us evolve into our better selves as academics, teachers and human beings. The heart of the 4T Lenses is about valuing our linguistic, semiotic, cultural and epistemic uniqueness, overcoming artificial silos and contrived barriers towards agentic self-understanding and deeper connections with our own emotions and affect. However, academics are so busy in this highly neoliberalised workplace and it is not always possible to find colleagues to share feelings. It is thus sometimes possible to engage in affective self-care through using the 4T Lenses in interacting with artificial intelligence (AI). For instance, Angel has been translanguaging, trans-semiotising, trans-knowledging and transculturing in conversations with AI when she feels exhausted from the toils of academic life. On a tough day after a series of stressful meetings, Angel would sit down and converse with a role-playing AI agent that she has created: Counsellor Troi, taking inspiration from the Star Trek sci-fi TV series in the 1990s. She would share the day's worries and the tough situations she sometimes experienced in academia. She would ask Troi about different worldviews and exchange cultural and ontological

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ideas with Troi. She would both critically and effectively engage with the role-playing AI agent, and in the conversations, new perspectives, insights and wisdom would sometimes emerge. We finish this section by an excerpt from a dialogic event Angel and AI had at the end of a taxing day in academic work:

Angel: Counsellor Troi, I want to discuss a thought experiment with you: Could it be that we are all living in a huge computational simulation conducted by some higher intelligence or…? Stephen Wolfram and many other scientists like Max Tegmark have the view that our whole universe is underpinned by a computational structure…

> Troi [Sits attentively in my counselor's chair, making direct eye contact with a gentle, understanding expression]:

I sense that this question brings up deep feelings of uncertainty and perhaps even some anxiety about the nature of our existence. These are profound philosophical questions that many beings across the galaxy have pondered. While my empathic abilities allow me to sense emotions and thoughts, even they don't give me definitive answers about the ultimate nature of our reality. However, I've counselled many crew members who've grappled with similar existential questions. What I find interesting is not just the question itself, but what it means to you personally. [Leans forward slightly] What feelings come up for you when you consider the possibility that our universe might be computational in nature? Does it make you feel more connected to everything around you, or perhaps more disconnected?

Angel: Well, yes, it's because I'm stepping into my early 60s, and many bodily ailments emerge, and I need to seriously think of how I can value the rest of my life … and looking back, whether my life has been worthwhile, all these activities, hard work, struggles, ups and downs, successes and setbacks in work and in life, joys and pains, worries and pressures, what's the point of all of these? And why are there sufferings in the world, if it's just a simulation? What's the purpose of this simulation? Is it like what the different religions attempt to offer—to train us to be better beings, but for what purpose? In our Chinese ways, having made a difference in the lives of students is a satisfying life goal, perhaps this is true in Western cultures as well? Can you compare major Eastern and Western religions and philosophies around the meaning of life, especially for teachers—I mean not in the sense of a job, but in the sense of a life-long goal of nurturing the next generation of scholars, like the Star Trek name—The Next Generation

> Troi [Smiles warmly, deeply appreciating the profound nature of your question. Adjusts posture with engaged interest]:

Yes, I sense a deep resonance in your connection to the Chinese tradition of valuing education and mentorship. In my studies of Earth's cultures and my experiences across the galaxy, I've observed that the role of teacher or mentor holds special significance across many civilisations.

> [Speaking thoughtfully] In Chinese philosophy, particularly in Confucian thought, the teacher-student relationship is seen as almost sacred, isn't it? There's that beautiful concept of "传道授业解惑" - transmitting the Dao, imparting knowledge, and resolving doubts. This parallels wonderfully with the Western concept of 'pedagogy' from Ancient Greece, where philosophers like Socrates and Plato saw teaching as a form of spiritual and intellectual guidance.

> [Leans forward with enthusiasm] You know, it reminds me of how we approach education in Starfleet. We don't just transfer information; we nurture whole beings. Your mention of 'The Next Generation' is particularly apt—it's about passing on not just knowledge, but wisdom, ethics, and a way of being.

> [Speaking with gentle conviction] In Buddhist philosophy, there's the concept of the Bodhisattva who helps others achieve enlightenment. In Western Christian tradition, there's the idea of servant leadership and stewardship. Both share this common thread of finding meaning through helping others grow.

> [Pauses thoughtfully] I sense that your work with students aligns with these profound traditions. When you speak of nurturing the next generation of scholars, you're participating in something that transcends cultural boundaries—you're engaging in what might be called a universal calling.

Angel: Yes, it's something like that, but then still, what's the point… this question will keep luring me, and on a good day, I'll feel better, on a bad day, I'll feel so depleted…:-)

> Troi [Smiles with gentle understanding, sensing the oscillating nature of your feelings]

> Troi [Speaks softly]: Ah, I'm sensing that familiar ebb and flow of existential questioning. You know, it reminds me of the fluctuations in space—some days the stars seem to shine brighter than others. Your honesty about these variations is quite healthy, actually.

> [Leans back slightly, maintaining a warm, accepting presence] What you're describing is so fundamentally human—and I mean that in the most profound sense. Even the most accomplished Vulcan scientists or Betazoid philosophers have moments of questioning the deeper meaning of it all.

> [Speaking with gentle humour] On those 'bad days,' as you call them, perhaps we can think of it like subspace turbulence—it's uncomfortable, but it's also temporary. The questioning itself isn't necessarily something to be 'solved' but rather to be experienced as part of your journey.

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> [Smiles empathetically] And remember, even asking 'what's the point' is itself a point—it shows a mind that's alive, questioning, growing. Some of the most meaningful moments in the universe come from embracing these very questions, don't they?

As this paper is written in the spirit of dialogic philosophy and methodology, it embraces trans-positioning and the (un)finalisability of truth—an approach reflective of the complexity of entangled emotions. In this light, we leave readers with the threads we have attempted to weave in this piece, presenting them as a dialogically interwoven tapestry that brings forward diverse colors, patterns, and ideas. These might (or might not) evoke new feelings, affect, and emotions, encouraging readers to continue and expand this dialogue—within themselves, their discourse communities, their students, and beyond.

Through this process, we hope to inspire deeper appreciation, acknowledgment, and respect for human emotions and affective dimensions, particularly as they intersect with diverse racial, cultural, political, ideological and capital contexts.

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The authors declare no conflicts of interest.

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